SUN TEMPLE, MODHERA, GUJARAT



SHUTTERSTOCK

After Chalukya ruler Bhima I's troops withstood an attack by Mahmud of Ghazni during 1024-1025, their king is said to have commissioned this temple. It has been plundered over the years—the golden idol of the Sun God is no longer found in the *garbha griha*—but the intricate erotic and mythological carvings make the place unmissable. While the Sabha Mandap here stands on 52 pillars, signifying the 52 weeks in a year, the Surya Kunda, shaped like a stepwell, is meant to signify the union of fire and water. Among sun temples, Konark and Kashmir's Martand grab all headlines, but it's at Modhera that one truly sees the light.

WHAT ELSE TO DO

The Rani Ki Vav stepwell in nearby Patan is architecturally brilliant and a Unesco heritage site since 2014.

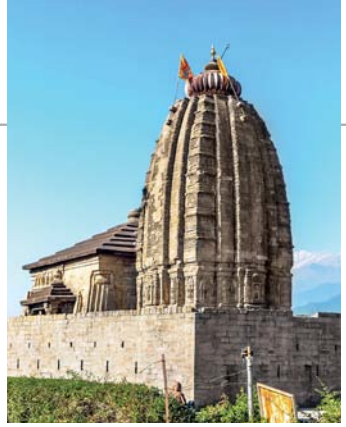


WHAT ELSE TO DO

The Subramaniya Swamy Kovil Beach is ideal for some rest and relaxation, but if you want to add some sightseeing to your trip, do visit the Panchalankurichi Fort and Valli's Cave.

SUBRAMANIYA SWAMY TEMPLE, TIRUCHENDUR, TAMIL NADU

Also known as 'Skanda', Murugan, Shiva's son, is said to have used his mighty spear to defeat the netherworld's forces at Tiruchendur. Believed to be one of Murugan's six abodes, Tiruchendur sits by the Bay of Bengal, and the Subramaniya Swamy Temple itself has been built by its shores. Its 157-ft *gopuram* is arresting. After bathing in the ocean, pilgrims often cleanse themselves in the Naazhi Kinaru, a sacred well at the south of the temple complex.



SHUTTERSTOCK

BAIJNATH TEMPLE, BAIJNATH, HIMACHAL PRADESH

The faithful often turn to deities for consolation in times of disease and illness. Himachal Pradesh's Baijnath Temple was built to shore up the health of Shiva's devotees. Here 'the God of Destruction' is worshipped as 'Vaidyanath', the Lord of Physicians. Devotees believe even the water here can cure their anguish. While some believe the *lingam* here is one of the original 12 *jyotirlingas*, the claim is often contested. The temple was built by two merchants, Ahuka and Manyuka, in 1204, and everything from its doorways and walls to its sanctum and porch has been carved to depict Shiva's beneficence and his significance in Hindu mythology.

WHAT ELSE TO DO

Just 28 km from Baijnath is Billing, a paragliding and aerosports site that is considered one of the best in the world. Palampur and its tea gardens are also only 16 km away.

WHAT ELSE TO DO

Ruins of the ancient 11th-century Kadeideol Shiva temple can be found on a nearby hill, while the Achanakmar Wildlife Sanctuary, declared a Tiger Reserve in 2009, is a 10-km drive away.



MAHAMAYA TEMPLE, RATANPUR, CHHATTISGARH

With lush hills around and close to 150 ponds, the Ratanpur town (a 25 km drive from Bilaspur) is conspicuously verdant. However, the bulk of visitors often come here not for nature, but hoping for a glimpse of Mahamaya Devi, a manifestation of the Durga as Mahishasur Mardini, the Slayer of Mahishasur. The nine days of Navratri see several pilgrims make a beeline for the temple's sanctum and *mandapa*, usually on empty stomachs. King Ratnadeva is said to have laid the foundation of this shrine in the 12th century after goddess Kali purportedly appeared to him in a divine vision.